

Audience Recognition



COMMUNICATION AT WORK

In this scenario, Home and Business Mortgage works to meet the company's commitment to diversity through its technical communication.

Home and Business Mortgage (HBM), a Phoenix, Arizona, company, prides itself on being a good neighbor and an asset to the community. Its goal is to ensure that the company meets all governmental personnel regulations, including those required by the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC), the Family Medical Leave Act (FMLA), and the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). HBM is committed to achieving diversity in its workplace.

In fact, the company is so focused on its appreciation of and commitment to diversity that HBM's technical communicators have created the following:

- Bilingual brochures, newsletters, and annual reports
- Brochures geared toward different stakeholders—senior citizens (age 55 and up); African-American, Hispanic, and Native American homebuyers; women; and young singles (18–25)
- A Web site with photographs depicting Phoenix's diverse population

HBM's Web site is unique in another important way. It has sought to abide by W3C WAI mandates. The World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) hosts the Web Accessibility

Learning Objectives

When you complete this chapter, you will be able to

- Recognize that high-tech readers understand acronyms, abbreviations, and jargon
- Understand that low-tech readers need glossaries or parenthetical definitions of technical terms
- Recognize that lay readers usually will not understand technical terms and often need extended definitions
- Consider issues of diversity, such as gender, race, religion, age, and sexual orientation
- Communicate with multiple audiences who have different levels of technical knowledge by considering the amount of technical content and terms you should include in your document
- Know that the definition of a technical term usually includes its type and distinguishing characteristics but can also include examples, descriptions, and procedures
- Communicate with multicultural audiences by defining terms, avoiding jargon and idioms, considering the context of the words you use, avoiding cultural biases, avoiding slash marks, being careful with humor, and allowing space for translation
- Avoid sexist language
- Get your audience involved in the text, by using pronouns, the reader's name, and revealing audience benefit
- Evaluate your audience using the audience checklist

Initiative (WAI). This initiative states that “the power of the Web is its universality. Access by everyone regardless of disability is an essential aspect.” HBM’s webmasters, in agreement with the WAI, realize that graphic-laden Web sites, as well as those with audio components, are not accessible to people with disabilities, such as hearing and visual impairment.

To meet this WAI platform, HBM’s webmasters have achieved the following at the company’s Web site:

- Provided links to access information in different languages.
- Avoided online audio.
- Limited online video and used the Alt attribute to describe each visual’s function.

- Increased the font of Web text to 20-point versus the standard 12- to 14-point font.
- Avoided all designer fonts, like cursive, which are hard to read online.
- Avoided red and green for color emphasis because these colors are hard to read for audiences with visual impairments.
- Avoided frames that not only fail to load on all computers but also create readability challenges online.

HBM is honored to serve all of its customers, regardless of race, age, religion, or physical challenges. One way to achieve the company’s commitment to diversity is through its technical communication.

When you write a memo, e-mail message, blog entry, Web site, instant message, tweet, letter, or report, someone reads it. That individual or group of readers is your audience. To compose effective technical communication, you should achieve audience recognition and audience involvement.

Audience Recognition

When you write, give an oral presentation, convene a meeting, communicate with customers in a salesroom, or make a speech at a conference, consider the following questions:

- Who is your audience?
- What does this reader or listener know?
- What does this reader or listener not know?
- What must you write or say to ensure that your audience understands your point?
- How do you communicate to more than one person (multiple audiences)?
- What is this person's position in relation to your job title?
- What diversity issues (gender, sexual orientation, cultural, multicultural) must you consider?

If you do not know the answers to these questions, your communication might contain jargon or acronyms the reader will not understand. The tone of the e-mail may be inappropriate for management (too dictatorial) or for your subordinates (too relaxed). Your communication might not consider your audience's unique culture and language. To communicate successfully, you must recognize your audience's level of understanding. You also should factor in your audience's unique personality and traits, which could impact how successfully you communicate.

See Table 1 for a summary of audience variables to consider when communicating.

Knowledge of Subject Matter

What does your audience know about the subject matter? Does the person work closely with you on the project? That would make the audience a high-tech peer. Does the audience

TABLE 1 Audience Variables

Knowledge of Subject Matter

- High tech
- Low tech
- Lay
- Multiple

Personality Traits

- Audience's perceived personality
- Audience's attitude or position regarding the topic
- Audience's preference regarding style
- Audience's response to the topic

Issues of Diversity

- Age
 - Gender
 - Race and/or religion
 - Sexual orientation
 - Language and/or culture of origin—multicultural or cross-cultural
-

have general knowledge of the subject matter but a different area of expertise? That would make the audience a low-tech peer. Is the audience totally uninvolved in the subject matter? That would make the person a lay audience. Finally, could your audience be a combination of these types? Then, you would be communicating with an audience with multiple levels of expertise.

High-Tech Audience. High-tech readers work in your field of expertise. They might work directly with you in your department, or they might work in a similar capacity for another company. Wherever they work, they are your colleagues because they share your educational background, work experience, or level of understanding.

If you are a computer programmer, for example, another computer programmer who is working on the same system is your high-tech peer. If you are an environmental engineer working with hazardous wastes, other environmental engineers focusing on the same concerns are your high-tech peers.

Once you recognize that your reader is high tech, what does this tell you? High-tech readers have the following characteristics:

- They are experts in the field you are writing about. If you write an e-mail message to a department colleague about a project you two are working on, your associate is a high-tech peer. If you write a letter to a vendor requesting specifications for a system she markets, that reader is a high-tech expert. If you write a proposal geared toward your colleagues, they are high tech.
- Because their work experience or education is comparable to yours, high-tech readers share your level of understanding. Therefore, they will understand high-tech jargon, acronyms, and abbreviations. You do not have to explain to an electronic technician, for example, what MHz means. Defining megahertz for this high-tech reader would be unnecessary.
- High-tech readers require minimal detail regarding standard procedures or scientific, mathematical, or technical theories. Two biomedical technologists, when discussing a metabolic condition in which the body cannot buffer changes in pH, do not need to define pH or acidosis (the terms being discussed).
- High-tech readers need little background information regarding a project's history or objectives unless the specific subject matter of the correspondence is new to them. If, for example, you are writing a status report to your supervisor, who has been involved in a project since its inception, then you will not need to flesh out the history of the project. On the other hand, if a new supervisor is hired or if you are updating a colleague new to your department, even though these readers are high tech, you will need to provide background data.

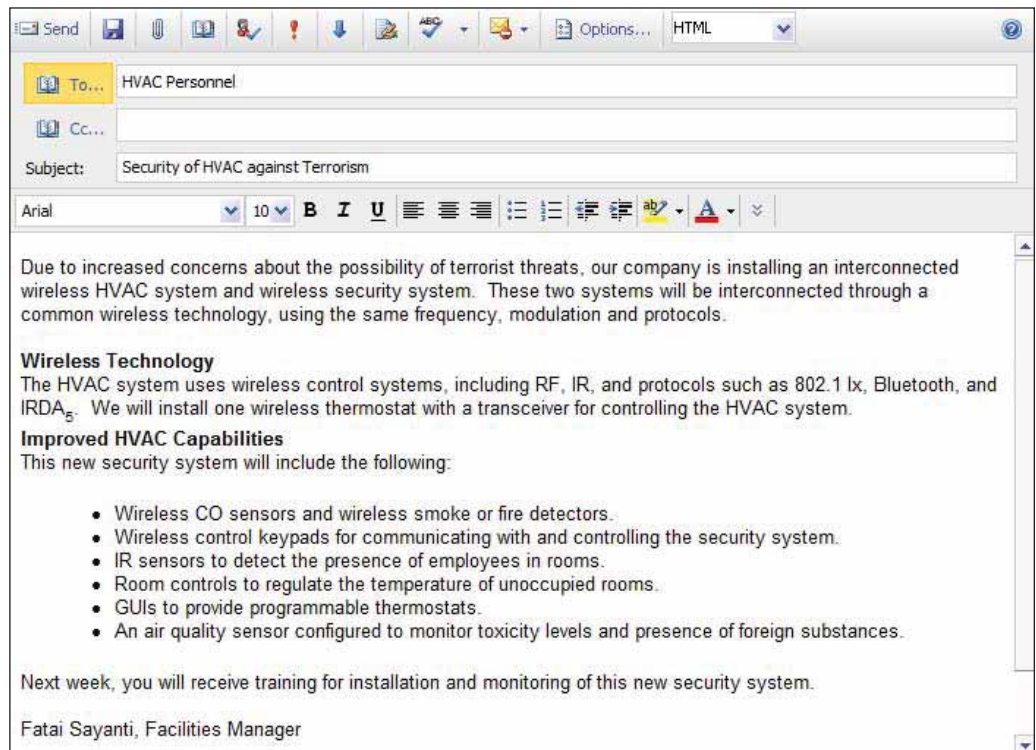
Figure 1 is an e-mail message to high-tech HVAC employees, informing them of the capabilities of a new HVAC security system. In contrast, Figure 2 discusses the same topic for a low-tech audience.

Low-Tech Audience. Writing in the workplace, however, rarely allows you to communicate only with high-tech readers. You also will write to low-tech readers. Low-tech readers include your coworkers in other departments. Low-tech readers also might include your bosses, subordinates, or colleagues who work for other companies. For instance, if you are a biomedical equipment technician, the accountant or personnel director or graphic artists in your company are low-tech peers. These individuals have worked around your company's equipment and, therefore, are familiar with your technology. However, they do not understand the intricacies of this technology.

Although your colleagues at other companies might have your level of education or work experience, they could be low tech if they are not familiar with your company's

FIGURE 1 E-mail Message to a High-tech Audience

This e-mail, written to high-tech readers, uses terminology without explanation or definition. Its tone is businesslike and directive.



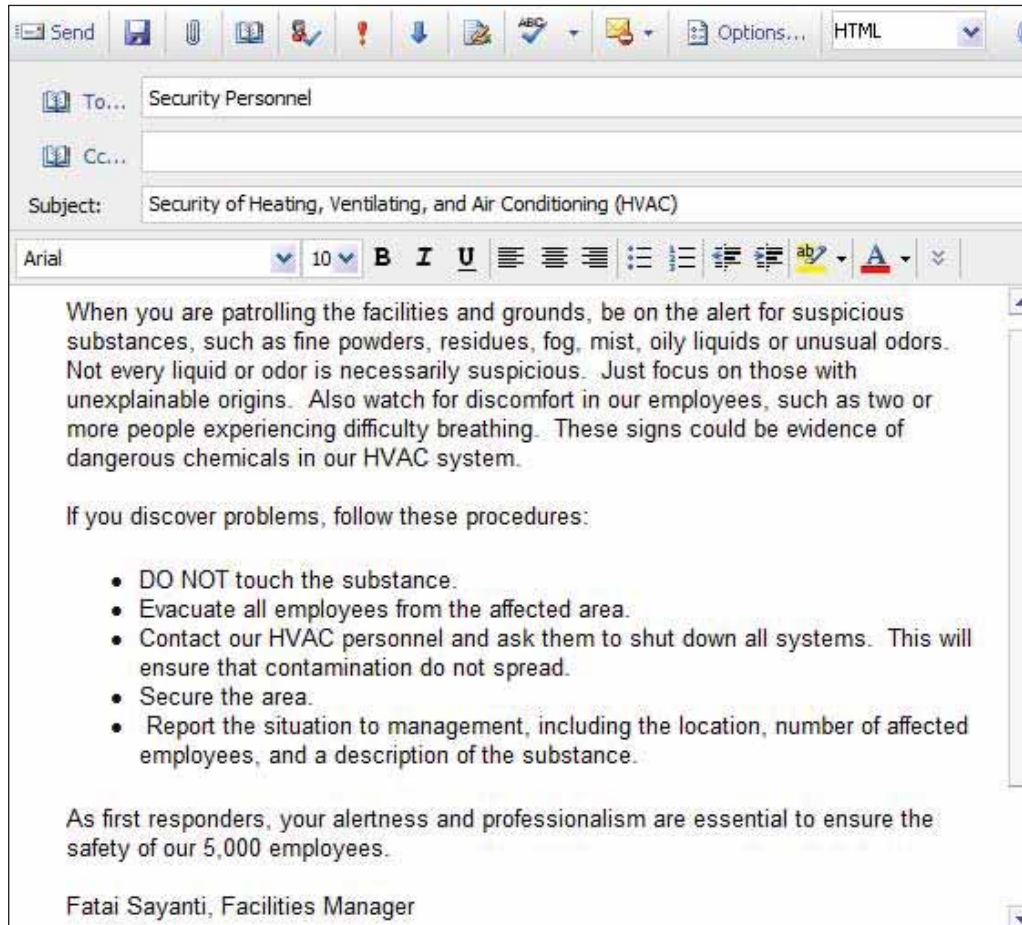
procedures or in-house jargon, acronyms, and abbreviations. When you write e-mail, letters, and reports to low-tech readers, remember that they share the following characteristics:

- Low-tech readers are familiar with the technology you are writing about, but their job responsibilities are peripheral to the subject matter. They either work in another department, manage you, work under your supervision, or work outside your company.
- Because low-tech readers are familiar with your subject matter, they understand some abbreviations, jargon, and technical concepts. To ensure that readers understand your content, therefore, define your terms. An abbreviation like BCA can't stand alone. Define it parenthetically: BCA (Burst Cutting Area).
- Abbreviations, acronyms, and technical jargon like burst cutting area sometimes need follow-up explanations. You should write, "BCA (Burst Cutting Area) is a circular section located near the center of a DVD disc where manufacturing information can be inscribed in a barcode."
- In addition, technical concepts must be defined for low-tech readers. For example, whereas high-tech readers understand the function of pressure transducers, a low-tech reader needs further information, such as "Pressure transducers: Solid-state components sense proximal pressure in the patient tubing circuit. The transducers convert this pressure value into a proportional voltage for the control system."
- Since the low-tech reader is not someone to whom you write often regarding your field of expertise, provide more background information. When you submit a status report to upper-level management, for example, don't just begin with work accomplished. Explain why you are working on the project (objectives, history), who is involved (other personnel), when the project began and its scheduled end date, and how you are accomplishing your goals. Low-tech readers understand the basic concepts of your work, but they have not been involved in it daily. Fill them in on past history.

Figure 2 is an e-mail to low-tech security personnel, informing them of procedures to follow if they discover suspicious substances on site.

Lay Audience. Customers and clients who neither work for your company nor have any knowledge about your field of expertise are the lay audience. If you work in network

FIGURE 2 E-mail Message to a Low-tech Audience



This e-mail to low-tech readers deals with a very important subject (security in the face of potential terrorism). The writer presents only what the audience needs to know in order to complete their job responsibilities. The writer conveys this content simply, using short sentences, a list, and easy-to-understand words. HVAC is defined.

communications for a cable company, for example, and you write an e-mail to a client regarding a problem with the high-speed Internet connection, your audience is a lay reader. If your field of expertise is biomedical equipment and you write a user manual for the patient, you are writing to a lay audience. If you are an automotive technician writing a service report for a customer, that customer is a lay reader.

Although you understand your technology, your reader, who uses the high-speed Internet service or the medical equipment or the car, is not an expert in the field. These readers are using your equipment or require your services, but the technology you are writing about is not within their daily realm of experience.

This makes writing for a lay audience difficult. To write successfully to a lay audience, remember that these readers share the following characteristics:

- Lay readers are unfamiliar with your subject matter and terminology. Therefore, you should write simply. That's not to say that you should insult your lay reader with a remedial discussion or with a patronizing tone. You must, however, explain your topic clearly through precise word usage, depth of detail, and simple graphics.

FIGURE 3 Letter from a High-Tech Writer to a Lay Audience

This letter from a high-tech writer to a lay audience defines all terms and avoids abbreviations.

The writer recognizes his lay audience by defining the high-tech terms "retrofitting" and "a tight envelope." To motivate the audience, the writer uses positive words like "easy" and "cost-effective."

Cottrell & Schneider Engineering
5117 East 31st Street
Kansas City, MO 64128

May 6, 2014

Dr. Jamie Wilson
Superintendent, Parkton Independent School District
205 Main
Parkton, MO 65110

Dear Dr. Wilson:

Thank you for inviting Cottrell & Schneider Engineering and GreenLive to work with you on plans for new construction and retrofitting of Parkton schools. Dale Askew, from GreenLive, and I have completed our review of the Parkton Independent School District. To ensure that your facilities meet green construction principles, we are proposing the following energy-saving building changes:

1. **Net-zero Energy.** Currently, your facilities draw energy from the city's grid. The goal of net-zero energy is to ensure that buildings generate, on their own sites, at least as much energy as they use. By installing only four wind turbines on the southwest corner of your high school (currently used for overflow parking), your entire district can produce as much power from renewable sources as from the city's grid.
2. **Retrofitting.** Our studies show that your buildings lose approximately 36 percent heat and cooling from air seepage. By retrofitting the current sites (no new construction needed), you can achieve what's known in the industry as "a tight envelope." This means that by sealing floor-to-wall joints, insulating roofs, and wrapping pipes—all easy and cost-effective fixes—Parkton can earn the coveted Platinum certification. Only businesses that are at least 80 percent energy efficient earn this award.
3. **Solar Panel Installation.** GreenLive provided two great options for solar power. Crystalline cell modules, common to flat panel installation, are somewhat costly but very efficient. Thin-film modules are less expensive but also less efficient. Still, they are a good option for building retrofits like you're considering. We'll be happy to provide you more details on each option.
4. **Biophilic design.** This green technology incorporates nature in building construction. We can create vegetated roofs (partially covering your roof with grass, reeds, and bushes); rammed earth walls (building walls out of sustainable materials like earth, chalk, lime, and gravel); operable windows that open to let in light and air; skylights; and ventilation systems that let fresh air into your buildings. Not only will these techniques improve energy consumption, but also biophilic designs have proven to positively impact morale.

Once you have reviewed the attached construction and retrofit plans, Dr. Wilson, please call or e-mail me (682-0011 or mwalker@cottrell&schneider.com). I look forward to answering your questions and working with you on ways to make Parkton schools green.

Sincerely,

Mike Walker

Mike Walker, CEO Cottrell & Schneider Engineering

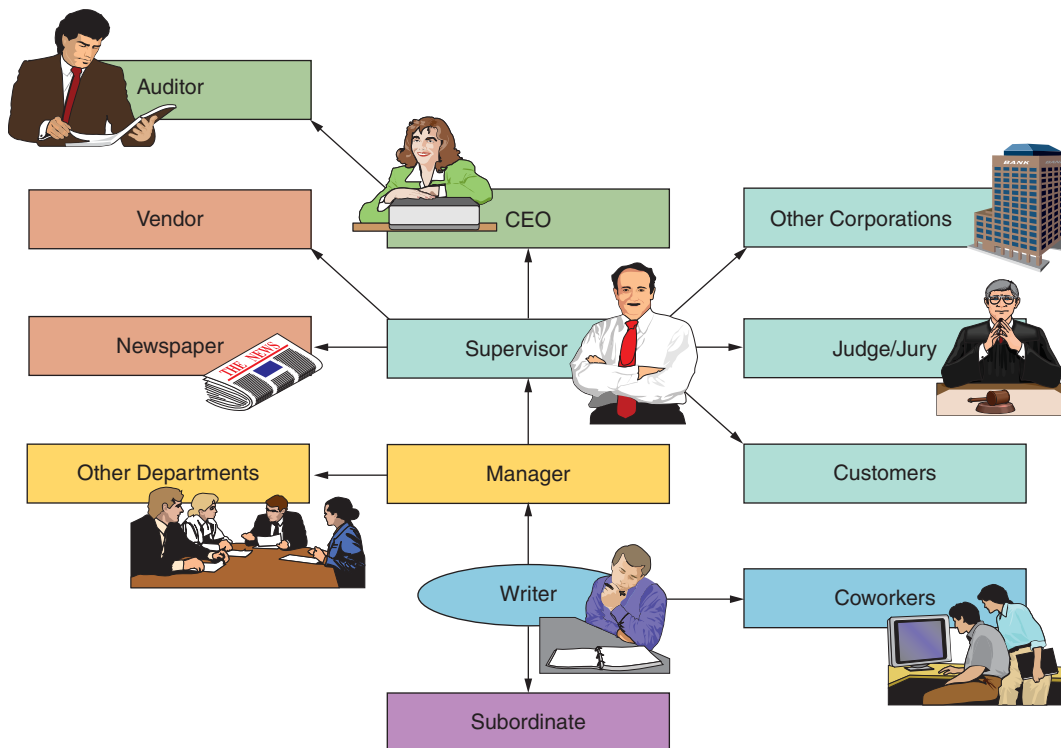
- Because your lay readers do not understand your terminology or work environment, they won't understand your in-house jargon, abbreviations, or acronyms. Avoid high-tech terms or define them thoroughly.
- Lay readers will need background information. If you leap into a discussion about a procedure without explaining to your lay readers why they should perform each step, they will not understand the causes or rationale. High-tech and possibly even low-tech readers might not need such explanations, but the lay reader needs clarity.

For example, look at the letter about green construction principles from a high-tech engineer to a lay audience, a school superintendent (Figure 3).

Composing effective technical communication requires that you recognize the differences among high-tech, low-tech, and lay audiences. If you incorrectly assume that all readers are experts in your field, you will create problems for yourself as well as for your readers. If you write using high-tech terms to low-tech or lay audiences, your readers will be confused and anxious. You will waste time on the phone or answering e-mail messages clarifying the points that you did not make clear in the technical document.

Multiple Audiences. Correspondence is not always sent to just one type of audience. Your correspondence may have an audience with multiple levels of expertise. Sometimes you write to high-tech, low-tech, and lay audiences simultaneously. For example, when writing a report, most people assume that their supervisor will be the only reader. This might not be the case, however. The supervisor could send a copy of your report to the manager, who could then submit the same report to the executive officer. Similarly, your supervisor might send the report to your colleagues or to your subordinates. Your report might be sent out to other lateral departments. Figure 4 shows the possibilities.

FIGURE 4 Examples of Possible Audiences



Writing correspondence for multiple readers with different levels of understanding and reasons for reading creates a challenge. When you add the necessity of using a tone that will be appropriate for all of these varied readers, the writing challenge becomes even greater.

How do you meet such a challenge? The first key to success is recognizing that multiple audiences exist and that they share the following characteristics.

- Your intended audience will not necessarily be your only readers. Others might receive copies of your correspondence.
- Some of the multiple readers will be unfamiliar with the subject matter. Proper background data (objectives, overviews) will clarify the history of the report for these readers. In a letter, report, e-mail message, Web site, or blog, this background information cannot be too elaborate. Often, all you do is provide a reference line, subject line, or link suggesting where the readers can find out more about the subject matter if they wish—“Reference: Operations Procedure 321 dated 9/21/14.” In longer reports, background data will appear in the summary or abstract, as well as in the report’s introduction.
- Multiple readers have diverse understandings of your technology. This requires that you define jargon, abbreviations, and acronyms.
- You might be writing correspondence in a collaborative team. If you’re the technical writer, you could work with SMEs (subject matter experts). These could include software developers, customer service personnel, project managers, business analysts, and more. To communicate effectively within your team, everyone needs to understand each other’s terminology.

Writing for Future Audiences

Time creates another challenge regarding audience recognition. Technical communication usually is archived for future reference. You might write an e-mail, report, proposal, or instruction using terms or focusing on content that your primary audience understands . . . at the moment. However, months (or years) later when the correspondence is retrieved from the files, will your readers still be familiar with the topic? Will you still have the same readers? Many people, some of whom didn’t even work for your company at the time of the original writing, will read your correspondence. These future readers need clarity, background information, and terms defined. Future readers could include

- judges and juries who depend on past reports to decide cases
- new employees at a company who retrieve filed documents to learn how to complete current tasks
- accountants and auditors who look at past records to find what work was accomplished at a prior date
- new managers or supervisors who need to familiarize themselves with workplace procedures
- technicians who need to implement current lab procedures based on past findings

Defining Terms for Audiences

Based on whether or not the current or future audience is high tech, low tech, lay, or multiple, you have to decide when to use acronyms, abbreviations, and technical terminology and how to use them effectively. One simple rule for low-tech, lay, and multiple audiences is to define your terms. You can do so as follows:

- parenthetically
- in a sentence

- in an extended paragraph
- in a glossary
- as online help with a pop-up definition

Defining Terms Parenthetically

Rather than just writing CIA, write CIA (Cash in Advance) or Cash in Advance (CIA). Such parenthetical definitions, which are only used once per correspondence, don't take a lot of time and won't offend your readers. Instead, the result will be clarity.

Defining Your Terms in a Sentence

If you provide a sentence definition, include the following:

Term + Type + Distinguishing characteristics.

For example, using a sentence to define *HTTP*, you would write the following:

HTTP (hypertext transfer protocol) is a **set of rules** for the secure transfer of files, including text, graphics, videos, and sound on the Internet.

Term points to "HTTP (hypertext transfer protocol)".
Type points to "set of rules".
Distinguishing characteristics points to "for the secure transfer of files, including text, graphics, videos, and sound on the Internet."

◀ EXAMPLE

Using Extended Definitions of One or More Paragraphs

When you need to provide an extended definition of a paragraph or more, in addition to providing the term, type, and distinguishing characteristics, also consider including examples, procedures, and descriptions. Look at the following paragraph definition of a video card.

A video card (graphics accelerator card, display adapter, or graphics card) is a type of printed circuit board that can be inserted into an expansion slot of a computer's motherboard. The video card creates and outputs images to a display. Functions of a video card can include video capture, MPEG-2 and MPEG-4 decoding, TV output, or the ability to connect multiple monitors.

◀ EXAMPLE

Using a Glossary

If you have not defined your terms parenthetically, in a sentence, or in a paragraph, you should use a glossary. A glossary is an alphabetized list of terms placed after your conclusion/recommendation.

GLOSSARY

ADC	analog to digital converter
Analog	a variable signal continuous in both time and amplitude
DAC	digital to analog converter
LAN	local area network
PSTN	public switched telephone network—analogue phone systems
ROI	return on investment
Voice signal	allows users to access phone options with a single voice command
VoIP	voice over Internet protocol
WAN	wide area network

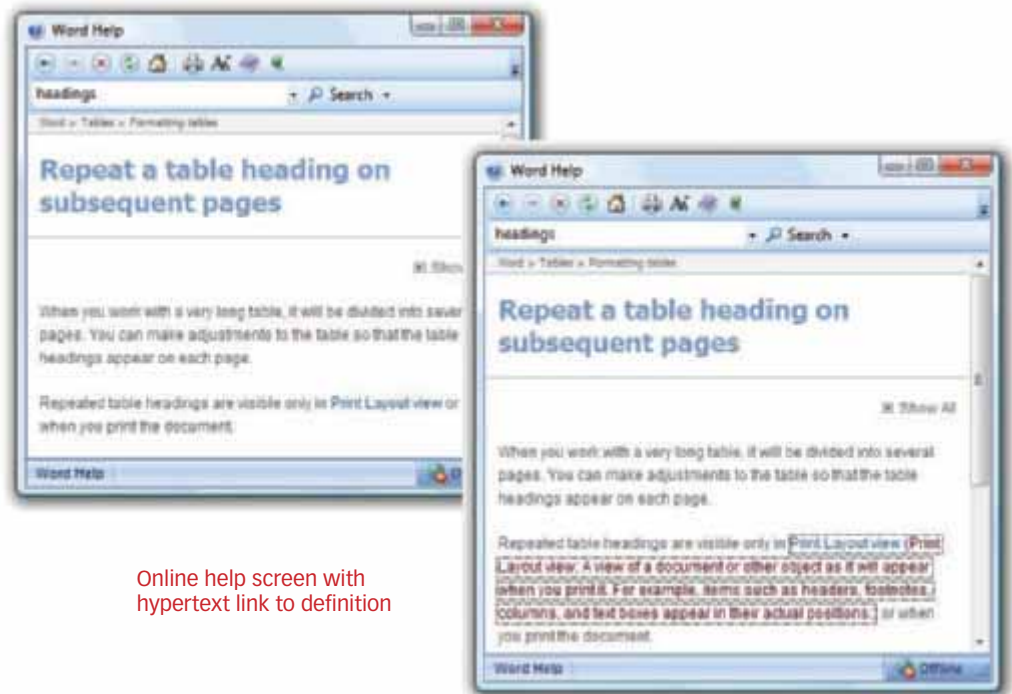
◀ EXAMPLE

Providing Pop-ups and Links with Definitions

Use pop-up screens for online help. (See Figure 5.)

FIGURE 5 Online Help Screen with Pop-up Definition

Pop-up definition of
"Print Layout view"



Online help screen with
hypertext link to definition

Audience Personality Traits

In addition to considering an audience's level of knowledge, a technical communicator should determine aspects of an audience's personality. By considering personality traits, the writer then can write appropriately using the proper tone, visual aids, and writing style. This will help the writer meet the audience's needs. Of equal importance, by recognizing the audience's personality traits, the writer can more effectively get the desired response from the reader.

Let us start with a caveat. You obviously cannot always know your audience's personality traits. This would be a difficult goal to achieve when working with customers you've never met, a dispersed team of coworkers located in different cities, members of an audience at a large conference, or the widely diverse audience that reads your Web site or blog postings. However, many times you will write or speak to an audience that you know. This could include customers you have served in the past, vendors you often work with, as well as coworkers in your office and your immediate supervisors. To communicate successfully with an audience whom you know, factor in your knowledge of their personalities, attitudes, and preferences.

For example, we work with a company that offers its employees a pay incentive. The company will pay employees to identify a problem in the workplace and then suggest solutions to this problem. The goal is to improve the company's services, efficiency, budget, and profits. To earn this monetary award, the employees must write a report analyzing the perceived problem and proposing the solutions, create PowerPoint slides regarding the topic, and make a brief oral presentation to their supervisors.

We have found from interviews that employees who successfully earn the financial incentive assess their audience's personality. An audience's personality traits and possible responses to a topic of discussion can include issues such as those shown in Table 2. Reviewing these considerations will help you determine the type of content you want to provide, how persuasive you need to be, and what tone and style your technical communication must achieve.

TABLE 2 Audience Personality Traits and Responses

Audience's perceived personality
• Slow to act? • Eager? • Receptive? • Questioning? • Organized? • Disorganized? • Oppositional?
Audience's attitude or position regarding the topic
• Negative? • Positive? • Noncommittal? • Informed? • Uninformed?
Audience's preference regarding style
• Will he, she, or they accept contractions? • Should you use first names, last names, or position titles? • Is short and to-the-point better? • Is long and detailed better?
Desired audience response
• Do you want the audience to consider this idea and pass on a recommendation? • Do you want the audience to act now? • Do you want the audience to confirm what has been suggested? • Do you want the audience to reject some options but act on others? • Do you want the audience to file this information for future reference?

Biased Language—Issues of Diversity

Your readers or listeners will more than likely be diverse. Diversity includes “gender, race/ethnicity, religion, age, sexual orientation, class, physical and mental characteristics, language, family issues, [and] departmental diversity” (Grimes and Richard 8).

Think of it this way: You work for a city government, and your audience is the citizenry. Who comprises your city's populace? Or you work in a hospital. Who will visit your facility? Or you work in a retail establishment. Who will shop there? They are people of many different interests, levels of knowledge, and backgrounds—and they are all valuable to your business.

Why should you be concerned about a diverse audience?

1. **Diversity is protected by the law.** Prejudicial behavior and discrimination on the job will not be tolerated. “Non-compliance with Equal Opportunity or Affirmative Action legislation can result in fines and/or loss of contracts” (McInnes).
2. **Respecting diversity is the right thing to do.** People should be treated equally, regardless of their age, gender, sexual orientation, culture, or religion.
3. **Diversity is good for business.** In a workplace where employees feel valued and respected, they feel more committed to the company (“What Is the ‘Business Case’ for Diversity?”). Clients and customers prefer shopping in an environment devoid of prejudice. In addition, people from diverse backgrounds spend money and buy products. “To ensure that . . . products and services are designed to appeal to this diverse customer base, ‘smart’ companies are hiring people from those walks of life—for their specialized insights and knowledge” (McInnes).
4. **A diverse workforce keeps companies competitive.** Talent does not come in one color, nationality, or belief system. Instead, talent is “represented by people from a vast array of backgrounds and life experiences. Competitive companies cannot

DOT.COM UPDATES

Go to <http://www.shrm.org/diversity/> (the Society for Human Resource Management) for additional information about diversity in the workplace, including definitions, links, and articles about diversity in the news.

allow discriminatory preferences and practices to impede them from attracting the best available talent” (McInnes).

Diversity management is such an important concern that American businesses spend millions of dollars training employees to understand multiculturalism and diversity (Jordan 1). This is further verified in a Society for Human Resource Management survey of diversity initiatives, which reported that “84 percent of human resource professionals at Fortune 500 companies say their top-level executives think diversity management is important” (“What Is the ‘Business Case’ for Diversity?”).

Multiculturalism

Your company might market its products or services worldwide. International business requires multicultural communication, the sharing of written and oral information between businesspeople from different countries (Nethery). According to Edward Jones, an international investment company, “S&P 500 companies generate about half of their sales outside the U.S.” For example,

- “Nike generate[s] in excess of two-thirds of their sales outside the U.S.
- Yum! Brands (which operates Taco Bell, KFC, and Pizza Hut) generates more of its sales in China than in the U.S.
- GM sells more cars in China today than it does in the U.S.” (Bannister)

FAQs: Multiculturalism and Technical Communication in a Global Economy

Q: Why is “multiculturalism” important in technical communication? Doesn’t everyone in the United States speak English?

A: No, not everyone in the United States speaks English. Look at these facts:

- “With 170 different languages and dialects in the U.S., . . . more than 27.6 million people are limited English speakers” (“Marketing to the Multicultural U.S. Population”) 55.4 million Americans—or 20 percent—speak a language other than English at home.
- 35 million Americans speak Spanish in the home.
- 2.5 million Americans speak Chinese in the home.
- 1.4 million Americans speak French in the home (“New Census Bureau”).

Q: Though many people in the U.S. speak a language other than English, shouldn’t we write for the majority of our audience?

A: Your audience will be diverse—and the “majority” in the U.S. is changing.

- “America’s population has become increasingly diverse as Hispanics, African Americans, Asians, and people from many other segments rapidly contribute to the cultural richness of our population” (Melgoza).
- Hispanics number 48.4 million or 15.8 percent of the U.S. population.
- Asian Americans number approximately 13.6 million or 4.4 percent of the U.S. population (Demographics of the United States).

Source: “Demographics of the United States”

The Global Economy

For Coca Cola, which produces 300 different brands in 200 countries, 80 percent of their income is generated from outside the United States (Bannister). To accommodate its worldwide audience, Microsoft offers Windows XP Professional operating system in more than 100 different languages (“Set Up Windows XP for Multiple Languages”). Black & Veatch, a global engineering company, has office locations in Australia, Canada, Chile, China, India, Indonesia, Malaysia, Nepal, Puerto Rico, Russia, Singapore, Taiwan, Thailand, Turkey, the United Arab Emirates, the United Kingdom, the United States, and Vietnam.

Margaret Keating, vice president of operations for Hallmark Cards Inc., oversees Hallmark’s North American global operations. Her workforce of 6,000 employees is geographically dispersed. Much of her time is spent writing clear and concise communication to be translated into different languages (Cardarella D19).

The Challenges of Multicultural Communication. The Internet, e-mail, Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube affect global communication and global commerce constantly. With these technologies, companies can market their products internationally and communicate with multicultural clients and coworkers at a keystroke. An international market is great for companies because a global economy increases sales opportunities. However, international commerce also creates written and oral communication challenges. Companies that work internationally must communicate with all of their employees and clients; therefore, communication must be multilingual.

For example, Medtronic, a leading medical technology company, does business in 120 countries. Many of those countries mandate that product documentation be written in the local language. To meet these countries’ demands, Medtronic translates its manuals into 11 languages: French, Italian, German, Spanish, Swedish, Dutch, Danish, Greek, Portuguese, Japanese, and Chinese (Walmer 230).

Multilingual reports create unique communication challenges:

- Will each language version be identical in content and readability?
- Will the first language version suggest advantages to investors over translations?
- Are all translations carefully prepared according to tone, style, and content?
- Is each translation tested for usability and accuracy? (Courtis and Hassan 395).

See Figure 6 for an illustration of SurveyMonkey’s Web site with numerous language options.

Multicultural Team Projects. What about international, multilingual project work teams? If, for example, your U.S. company is planning to build a power plant in China, you will work with Chinese engineers, financial planners, and regulatory officials. To do so effectively, you will need to understand that country’s verbal and nonverbal communication norms. You also will have to know that country’s management styles, decision-making procedures, sense of time and place, and local values, beliefs, and attitudes.

Our natural instinct is to evaluate people and situations according to our sense of values, our cultural perspectives. That is called ethnocentrism—a belief that one’s own culture represents the norm. Such is not the case. The world’s citizenry does not share the same perspectives, beliefs, values, political systems, social orders, languages, or habits. Successful technical communication takes into consideration differences in language, nonverbal communication, and culture.

FIGURE 6 SurveyMonkey with Spanish Language Options

SurveyMonkey recognizes the importance of their global clientele. The SurveyMonkey Web site allows users to conduct surveys in one of 15 languages in addition to English, including Spanish, Dutch, German, French, Italian, and Portuguese.



Source: Courtesy of SurveyMonkey

Due to the multicultural makeup of your audience, you must ensure that your writing, speaking, and nonverbal communication skills accommodate language barriers and cultural customs. The classic example of one company's failure to recognize the importance of translation concerns a car that was named Nova. In English, *nova* is defined as a star that spectacularly flares up. In contrast, *no va* in Spanish is translated as "no go," a poor advertisement for an automobile.

Cross-cultural Workplace Communication

Multiculturalism will affect you not just when you communicate globally. You will be confronted with multicultural communication challenges even in your own city and state. "The challenge posed by the increasing cultural diversity of the U.S. workforce is perhaps the most pressing challenge of our times" (Grimes and Richard 9). Another term for this challenge is cross-cultural communication, writing and speaking between businesspeople of two or more different cultures within the same country (Nethery). Look at the statistics regarding America's melting pot, as shown in Figure 7 and Figure 8 ("Demographics of the United States").

These numbers are estimated to change. The United States Census projects that by 2050, the White population will fall in percentage to 46.3 percent, the African-American population remains 13 percent, and the Asian population will rise to around 8 percent. The Hispanic population will almost double to 30.3 percent, shown in Figure 8.

One of the challenges presented by the increasingly multicultural nature of our society and workplace is language. Language barriers are an especially challenging situation for hospitals, police and fire personnel, and governmental agencies where failure to communicate effectively can have dangerous repercussions.

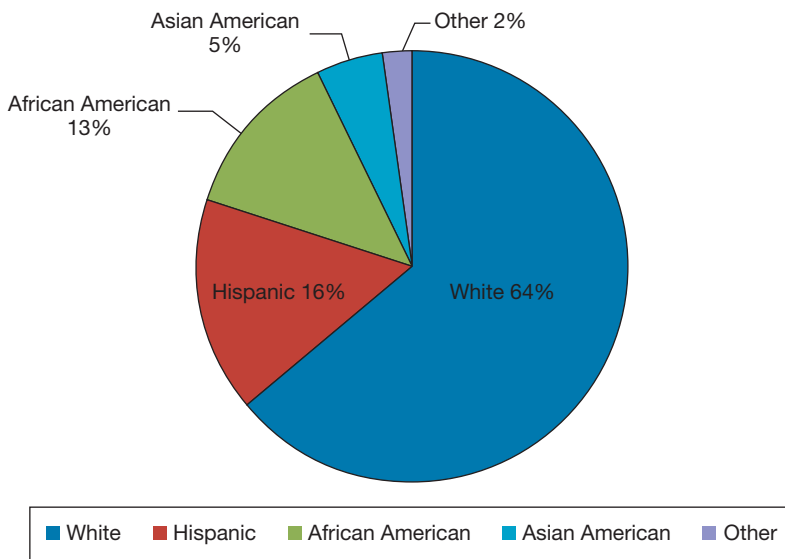
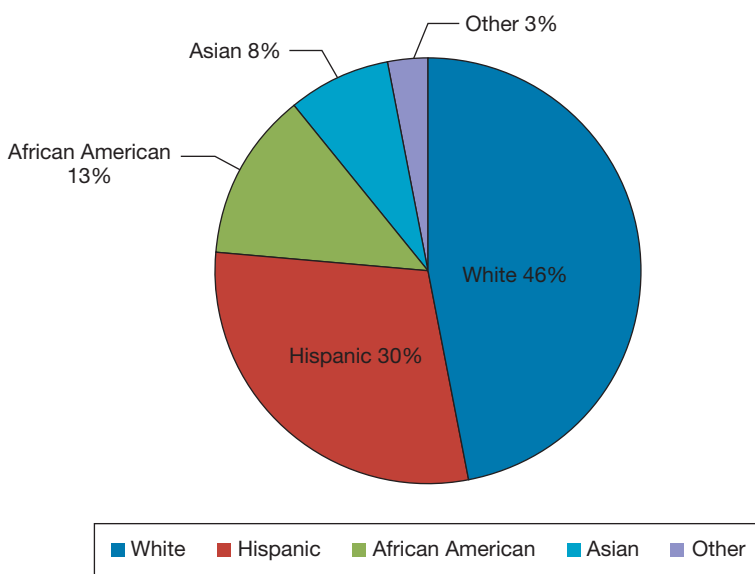
One hospital reported that it has "13 staff members supplying Spanish, Arabic and Somali translations." However, this hospital's successful use of translators to help with doctor-patient communication is rare. "Only about 14 percent of U.S. hospitals provide training for volunteer translators." Most hospitals depend on the patient's relatives. "In one case studied, an 11-year-old sibling translated. The child made 58 mistakes" (Sanchez A4). Imagine how such errors can negatively impact healthcare and medical records.

The communication challenges are not only evident for employees in healthcare and other community infrastructures. Industries as diverse as banking, hospitality (restaurants and hotels), construction, agriculture, meat production and packing, and insurance also face difficulties when communicating with clients and employees for whom English is a second language.

DOT.COM UPDATES

Check out these sites related to the importance of multiculturalism, cross-culturalism, and diversity:

- **Diversity in the Workplace** (http://www.business.com/directory/human_resources/diversity/) provides information about affirmative action, diversity training, minority-owned businesses, and related cultural issues.
- **International Business Multiculturalism and the Internet** (<http://www.infotoday.com/searcher/oct01/fink.htm>) provides an article and access to various Web sites related to the global economy.
- **American Society of Mechanical Engineers** (<http://www.professionalpractice.asme.org/communications/diversity/index.htm>) provides a great definition of workplace diversity and an overview of why diversity is important with case studies.

FIGURE 7 U.S. Census Population as of 2010**FIGURE 8** U.S. Population Projections for 2050

Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

To achieve effective multicultural technical communication, follow the guidelines in this section.

Define Acronyms and Abbreviations

Acronyms and abbreviations cause most readers a problem. Although you and your immediate colleagues might understand such high-tech usage, many readers won't. This is especially true when your audience is not native to the United States. For example, corporate employees often abbreviate the job title "system manager" as *sysmgr*. However, in German, the title "system manager" is called the "system leiter"; in French, it's "le responsable." The abbreviation *sysmgr*. would make no sense in either of these countries (Swenson WE-193).

SPOTLIGHT

Why do some corporations provide foreign language training for their employees?

Phil Wegman, Program Director of Skills Enhancement for the Center for Business and Technology, sighed deeply and said, "I receive two to three calls every day from companies, desperate for Spanish language training. They need to teach their supervisors how to communicate more effectively with customers as well as with employees for whom English is a second language."

Phil's client base covers literally hundreds of fields, including dental and medical, criminal justice, public safety, transit, government, and education, as well as industries such as hospitality management (hotels and restaurants), construction, casinos, manufacturing, warehousing, banking, retail, childcare, and accounting. Police, nurses, physicians, and paramedics, for example, have asked Phil to provide them occupational language training that is "work specific and real life." Then, when an emergency situation occurs, the safety personnel can ask, in Spanish, French, German, or Chinese, "Where does it hurt?"

McDonalds, Hardees, and Burger King supervisors need to know enough Spanish to be able to say to their staff, "here's how you ring up this sale," "here's how you make this meal," or "here's how you clean this piece of equipment." Of equal importance, these companies have asked Phil to teach their supervisors how to answer customer questions or to take customer orders. Many of these fast-food restaurants have on staff a worker who is fluent in a

second language. However, the pace is so hectic in fast food that the restaurants can't always pull that one employee off the job to handle the situation. Thus, *all* supervisors need enough language skills to provide direct commands, make simple statements, or answer common questions in a foreign language.

Sometimes, the needs are immediate . . . and life threatening. Phil says, "When a construction or manufacturing company is rolling out a new piece of equipment, where the learning

curve is enormous, language can be a huge barrier.

Maybe a company has either employees for whom English is a second language, or that company does business internationally. Fluency becomes mandatory to ensure productivity, quality, and personal safety." If the new machinery is operated incorrectly, due to a failure to understand the English instructions, the end products might not meet standards and, of greater concern, injuries can occur.

There is one more key component to language knowledge, Phil states. "When a company teaches its employees a different language, the company honors that culture. The company tells its client base, 'We're trying to learn who you are and what makes you unique.'" The company is learning cross-cultural information to minimize barriers; the company is saying to its staff and customers, "We respect who you are and we want to work with you. That's just good business."



Avoid Jargon and Idioms

The same dilemma applies to jargon and idioms, words and phrases that are common expressions in English but that could be meaningless outside our borders. Every day in the United States, we use "on the other hand" as a transitional phrase and "in the black" or "in the red" to denote financial status. What will these idioms mean in a global market? Following is a list of idioms that are commonly used in America but which will not translate well in other countries:

ballpark figure	eye on the prize
belt-tightening	face the music
bite the bullet	guesstimate
brownie points	jump through hoops
buck stops here	pass the buck
crunch time	pull the plug
dog-eat-dog world	shape up or ship out
drum up business	through the roof

Distinguish Between Nouns and Verbs

Many words in English act as both nouns and verbs. This is especially true with computer terms, such as "file," "scroll," "paste," "boot," "code," and "help." If your text will be

translated, make sure that your reader can tell whether you're using the word as a noun or a verb (Rains).

Watch for Cultural Biases/Expectations

Your text will include words and graphics. As a technical communicator, you need to realize that many colors and images that connote one thing in the United States will have different meanings elsewhere. For example, the idioms “in the red” and “in the black” will not necessarily communicate your intent when they are translated. Even worse, the colors black and red have different meanings in different cultures. Red in the United States connotes danger; therefore, “in the red” suggests a financial problem. In China, however, the word *red* has a positive connotation, which would skew your intended meaning. The word *black* often implies death and danger, yet “in the black” suggests financial stability. Such contradictions could confuse readers in various countries.

Animals represent another multicultural challenge. In the United States, we say you're a “turkey” if you make a mistake, but success will make you “soar like an eagle.” The same meanings don't translate in other cultures. Take the friendly piggy bank, for example. It represents a perfect image for savings accounts in the United States, but pork is a negative symbol in the Mideast. If you are “cowed” by your competition in the United States, you lose. Cows, in contrast, represent a positive and sacred image in India.

Be Careful When Using Slash Marks

Does the slash mark mean “and,” “or,” or both “and/or”? The word “and” means “both,” but the word “or” means “one or the other,” not necessarily both. If your text will be translated to another language, will the translator know what you meant by using a slash mark? To avoid this problem, determine what you want to say and then say it.

Avoid Humor and Puns

Humor is not universal. In the United States, people talk about regional humor. If a joke is good in the South but not in the North, how could that same joke be effective overseas? Microsoft's software package Excel is promoted by a logo that looks like an X superimposed over an L. This visual pun works in the United States because we pronounce the letters X and L just as we would the name of the software package. If your readers are not familiar with English, however, they might miss this clever sound-alike image (Horton 686).

Realize That Translations May Take More or Less Space

An even greater problem occurs when you are writing for the Internet. On a Web site, you will provide a navigation bar and several frames. Why is this a problem? The word count of a document written in English will expand more than 30 percent when translated into some European languages. In Table 3, notice how English words become longer when translated into other languages (Horton 691).

TABLE 3 Translations Increase Word Length

English Word	Translations into Other Languages
Print	<i>Impression</i> (French)
File	<i>Archivo</i> (Spanish)
View	<i>Visualizzare</i> (Italian)
Help	<i>Assistance</i> (French)
E-mail	<i>Courriel</i> (Swiss)

The Swiss government is trying to curb what it defines as “the encroachment of English.” To do so, the government’s French Linguistics Service asked its citizens to avoid using the word “spam,” instead opting for *courrier de masse non sollicité*, meaning “unsolicited bulk mail” (“Swiss fight encroachment of English” A16).

Whereas the above examples add length to a document, “Chinese character writing captures the subject matter more compactly than English. Consequently, the length of the Chinese translation is usually about 60 percent of that needed by the English version” (Courtis and Hassan 397). You must consider length to accommodate translations.

Consider Paper Size

If your writing will be conveyed not on paper but on disk or on the Internet, you must consider software’s line-length and screen-length restrictions. For example, a page of hard-copy text in the United States will consist of approximately 55 lines that average 80 characters per line. How could this present a problem? The standard sheet of paper in the United States measures $8\frac{1}{2} \times 11$ inches. In contrast, the norm in Europe for standard-sized paper is A4— 210×297 millimeters, or 8.27×11.69 inches.

Why is the size of paper important? Here is the problem: If you format your text and graphics for an $8\frac{1}{2} \times 11$ -inch piece of paper in Atlanta, travel to London, download the files on a computer there, and hit Print, you might find that what you get is not what you hoped for. The line breaks will not be the same. You will not be able to three-hole punch and bind the text. The margins will be off, and so will the spacing on your flowchart or table (Scott 20-21).

Avoid Figurative Language

Many of us use sports images to figuratively illustrate our points. We “tackle” a chore; in business, a “good defense is the best offense”; we “huddle” to make decisions; if a sale isn’t made, you might have “booted” the job; if a sale is made, you “hit a home run.” Each of these sports images might mean something to native speakers, but they may not communicate worldwide. Instead, say what you mean, using precise words (Weiss 14).

Be Careful with Numbers, Measurements, Dates, and Times

For multicultural audiences, be sure to clarify which numbering system you use for measurements and how dates and times are written.

Numbers and Measurements. If your text uses measurements, you are probably using standard American inches, feet, and yards. However, most of the world measures in metrics. Thus, if you write $18 \text{ high} \times 20 \text{ wide} \times 30 \text{ deep}$, what are the measurements? There is a huge difference between $18 \times 20 \times 30$ inches and $18 \times 20 \times 30$ millimeters.

Dates. In the United States, we tend to abbreviate dates as MM/DD/YY: 05/03/14. In the United Kingdom, however, this could be perceived as March 5, 2014, instead of May 3, 2014. See Table 4 for additional examples.

TABLE 4 Different Ways of Understanding and Writing the U.S. Date 05/03/14

Country	Date
United States	May 3, 2014
United Kingdom	March 5, 2014
France	5 mars 2014
Germany	5. März 2014
Sweden	14-05-03
Italy	5.3.14

Time. Time is another challenge. Table 5 shows how different countries write times.

TABLE 5 Different Ways of Writing the U.S. Time 5:15 P.M.

Country	Time
United States	5:15 P.M.
France	17:15
Germany	17.15
Quebec, Canada	17 h 15

In addition to different ways of writing time, you must also remember that even within the United States, 1:00 P.M. does not mean the same thing to everyone. Is that central time, Pacific time, mountain time, or eastern time?

Another challenge with time occurs when we incorrectly assume that everyone everywhere abides by the same work hours. In the United States, the average workweek is 40 hours, and the typical workday is from 8:00 A.M. to 5:00 P.M. However, this is not the norm globally. French laws have reduced the workweek to 35 hours. Many Middle Eastern countries close work on Friday, the beginning of Sabbath. Offices in parts of southern Europe shut down for a traditional two-hour lunch (noon to 2 P.M.) (St. Amant “Communication” 28). Therefore, if you write an e-mail telling a coworker in Spain or Jordan that you will call at 1:00 P.M. his or her time, that could be an inappropriate time for your audience.

Finally, even simple words like *today*, *yesterday*, or *tomorrow* can cause problems. Japan is 14 hours ahead of U.S. eastern standard time. Thus, if you need a report *tomorrow*, do you mean tomorrow—the next day your time—or tomorrow—two days from your reader’s time? To solve these problems, determine your audience and make changes accordingly. That might mean

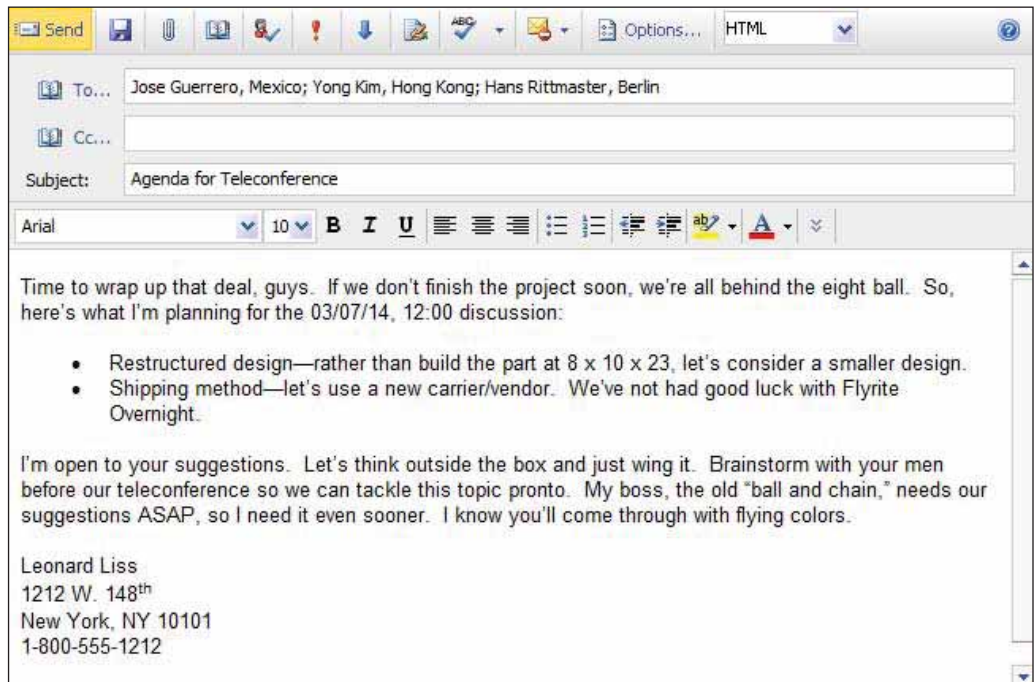
- Writing out the date completely (January 12, 2014)
- Telling the reader what standard of measurement you will use (“This document provides all measurements in metrics.”)
- Telling the reader what scheme of time presentation you will use (“This document relates time using a 24-hour clock rather than a 12-hour clock.”)
- Using multiple formats (“Let’s meet at 2:30 P.M./14:30.”)
- Avoiding vague words like today, tomorrow, or yesterday
- Recognizing that people have different work schedules globally

Use Stylized Graphics to Represent People

A photograph or realistic drawing of people will probably offend someone and create a cultural conflict. You want to avoid depicting race, skin color, hairstyles, and even gender. To solve this problem, avoid shades of skin color, choosing instead pure white or black to represent generic skin. Use simple, abstract, even stick figures to represent people. Stylize hands so they are neither male nor female—and show a right hand rather than a left hand, if possible (a left hand is perceived as “unclean” in some countries) (Flint 241). Recognizing the importance of the global marketplace is smart business and a wise move on the part of the technical communicator.

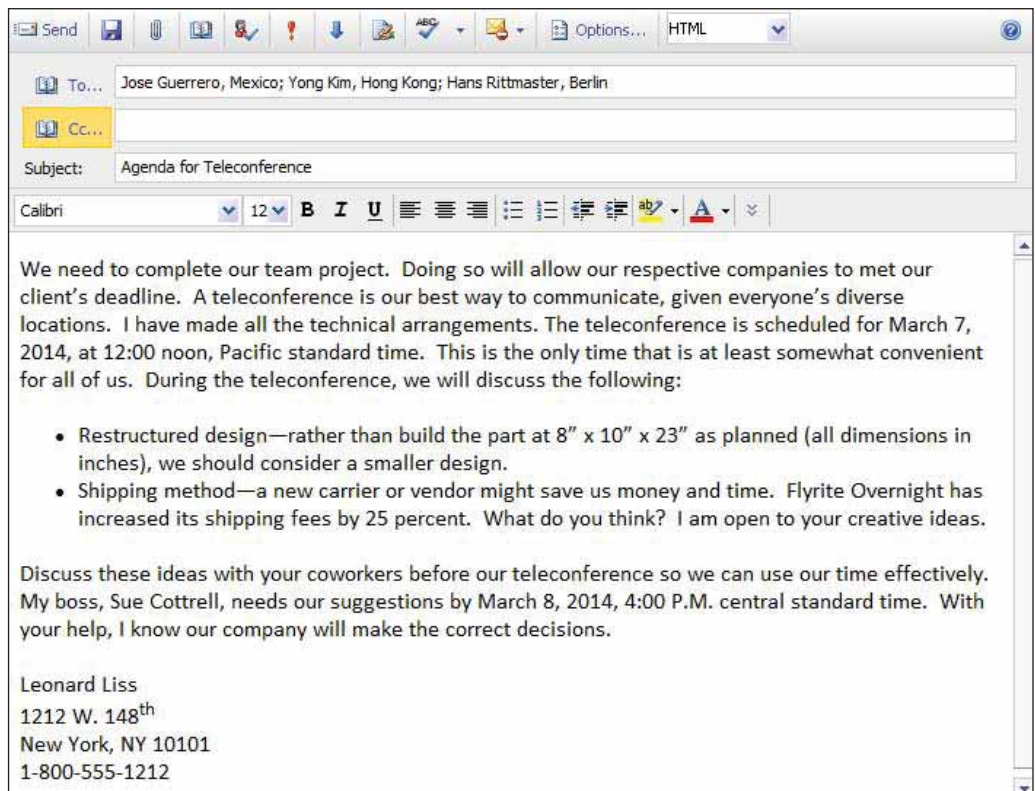
Following is an example of poor communication in an e-mail message for a multilingual audience.

BEFORE



In contrast, the following example corrects these communication problems:

AFTER



Avoiding Biased Language

In addition to recognizing your audience's level of knowledge, roles, and cultural diversity, you also must consider your audience's age, physical limitations, and gender.

Ageist Language

A word like “elderly” could imply feebleness. The words “old folks” create a negative image. To avoid these biases, write “people over seventy” or “retirees.” Better yet, avoid reference to age.

BEFORE	AFTER
Professor Jones, an elderly teacher at State University, is publishing a textbook despite his age.	Professor Jones, a State University teacher, is publishing a textbook.

Biased Language about People with Disabilities

The word “handicap” creates a negative image. “Disability” is generally preferred. However, any euphemism can be offensive. You should avoid reference to a person's disabilities. If you need to refer to a physical problem, do so without negative characterizations.

BEFORE	AFTER
Debbie Brown, a blind market researcher, won employee of the month.	Debbie Brown, a market researcher, won employee of the month.
The AIDS victim changed insurance carriers.	The AIDS patient changed insurance carriers.
John suffers from diabetes.	John is diabetic.
Sheila is confined to a wheelchair.	Sheila uses a wheelchair.

Sexist Language

Many of your readers will be women. This does not constitute a separate audience category. Women readers will be high tech or low tech, management or subordinate. Thus, you don't need to evaluate a woman's level of understanding or position in the chain of command any differently than you do for readers in general.

Recognize, however, that women constitute at least half the workforce. As such, when you write, you should avoid sexist language, which is offensive to all readers. Let's focus specifically on ways in which sexism is expressed and techniques for avoiding this problem. Sexism creates problems through omission, unequal treatment, and stereotyping, as well as through word choice.

Ignoring Women or Treating Them as Secondary. When your writing ignores women or refers to them as secondary, you are expressing sexist sentiments. The following are examples of biased comments and their nonsexist alternatives:

BEFORE	AFTER
When setting up his experiment, the researcher must always check for errors.	When setting up experiments, the researcher must always check for errors.
As we acquired scientific knowledge, men began to examine long-held ideas more critically.	As we acquired scientific knowledge, people began to examine long-held ideas more critically.

Modifiers that describe women in physical terms not applied to men treat women unequally.

BEFORE

The poor women could no longer go on; the exhausted men ...

Mrs. Acton, a gorgeous blonde, is Joe Granger's assistant.

AFTER

The exhausted men and women could no longer go on.

Jan Acton is Joe Granger's assistant.

Stereotyping. If your writing implies that only men do one kind of job and only women do another kind of job, you are stereotyping. For example, if all management jobs are held by men and all subordinate positions are held by women, this is sexist stereotyping.

BEFORE

Current tax regulations allow a head of household to deduct for the support of his children.

The manager is responsible for the productivity of his department; the foreman is responsible for the work of his linemen.

The administrative assistant brought her boss his coffee.

The teacher must be sure her lesson plans are filed.

AFTER

Current tax regulations allow a head of household to deduct for child support.

Management is responsible for departmental productivity. Supervisors are responsible for their personnel.

The administrative assistant brought the boss's coffee.

The teacher must file all lesson plans.

Sexist language disappears when you use pronouns and nouns that treat all people equally.

Pronouns. Pronouns such as *he*, *him*, or *his* are masculine. Sometimes you read disclaimers by manufacturers stating that although these masculine pronouns are used, they are not intended to be sexist. They're only used for convenience. This is an unacceptable statement. When *he*, *him*, and *his* are used, a masculine image is created, whether or not such companies want to admit it.

To avoid this sexist image, avoid masculine pronouns. Instead, use the plural, generic *they* or *their*. You also can use *he or she* and *his or her*. Sometimes you can solve the problem by omitting all pronouns.

BEFORE

Sometimes the doctor calls on his patients in their homes.

The typical child does his homework after school.

A good lawyer will make sure that his clients are aware of their rights.

AFTER

Sometimes the doctor calls on patients in their homes.

Most children do their homework after school.

A good lawyer will make sure that clients are aware of their rights.

Gender-Tagged Nouns. Use nouns that are nonsexist. To achieve this, avoid nouns that exclude women and denote that only men are involved.

BEFORE

mankind

manpower

the common man

wise men

businessmen

policemen

fireman

foreman

chairman

stewardess/steward

waitress/waiter

AFTER

people

workers/personnel

the average citizen

leaders

businesspeople

police officers

firefighter

supervisor

chairperson/chair

flight attendant

server

Consider the following examples of sexist and nonsexist writing in a letter advertising landscaping services. In the second example, the sexist terms are replaced with nonsexist boldfaced words.

BEFORE

DB and Sons Landscaping
1349 Elm
Oakland Hills, IA 20981

April 2, 2014

Owner
TurboCharge, Inc.
2691 Sommers Rd.
Iron Horse, IA 20992

Dear Sir:

Interested in beautifying your company property, with no care or worries? We have been in business for over 25 years helping **men** just like you. Here's what we can offer:

1. Shrub Care—your **workmen** will no longer need to water shrubs. We'll take care of that with a sprinkler system geared toward your business's unique needs.
2. Seasonal System Checks—don't worry about your **foreman** having to ask **his** workers to turn on the sprinkler system in the Spring or turn it off in the Winter. Our **repairmen** take care of that for you as part of our contract.
3. New Annual Plantings—we plant rose bushes and daffodils that are so pretty, your secretary will want to leave **her** desk and pick a bunch for **her** office. Of course, you might want to do that for **her** yourself ☺.
4. Trees—we don't just plant annuals. We can add shade to your entire property. Just think how beautiful your parking lot will look with elegant elms, oaks, and maples. Then, when you have that company picnic, your employees and their **wives** will be surrounded by nature.

Call today for prices. Let our skilled **craftsmen** work for you!

Sincerely,

Derek Barton

Derek Barton

AFTER

DB and Sons Landscaping
1349 Elm
Oakland Hills, IA 20981

April 2, 2014

Owner
TurboCharge, Inc.
2691 Sommers Rd.
Iron Horse, IA 20992

Subject: Sales Information

Interested in beautifying your company property, with no care or worries? We have been in business for over 25 years helping **business owners** just like you. Here's what we can offer:

- Shrub Care—your **employees** will no longer need to water shrubs. We'll take care of that with a sprinkler system geared toward your business's unique needs.
- Seasonal System Checks—don't worry about your **supervisor** having to ask **his or her** workers to turn on the sprinkler system in the Spring or turn it off in the Winter. Our **staff** takes care of that for you as part of our contract.
- New Annual Plantings—we plant rose bushes and daffodils that are so pretty, **all of your employees** will want vase-filled flowers on **their** desks.
- Trees—we don't just plant annuals. We can add shade to your entire property. Just think how beautiful your parking lot will look with elegant elms, oaks, and maples. Then, when you have that company picnic, your employees and **their families and friends** will be surrounded by nature.

Call today for prices. Let our skilled **experts** work for you!

Sincerely,

Derek Barton

Derek Barton

Audience Involvement

In addition to audience recognition, effective technical communication demands audience involvement. You not only need to know whom you are writing to in your technical correspondence (audience recognition), but also you need to involve your readers—draw them into your writing and keep them interested. Achieving audience involvement requires that you strive for personalized tone and reader benefit.

Personalized Tone

Companies do not write to companies; people write to people. Remember when you write your e-mail, letter, report, or procedure, another person will read it, so achieve a personalized, collaborative tone to involve your reader. Personalized tone is even more important in social media (Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, blogs, and so on) since this communication channel seeks to build community.

Pronouns. The best way to personalize correspondence is through pronoun usage. If you omit pronouns in your technical communication, the text will read as if it has been computer generated, absent of human contact. When you use pronouns in your technical communication, you humanize the text. You reveal that the memo, letter, report, or procedure is written by people, for people.

The generally accepted hierarchy of pronoun usage is as follows:

Pronoun	Focus
You Your	} The reader
We Us Our	
I Me My	} The ego

The first group of pronouns, *you* and *your*, is preferred. When you use *you* or *your*, you are speaking directly to your reader(s) on a one-to-one basis. The readers, whoever they are, read the word *you* or *your* and see themselves in the pronoun, envisioning that they are being spoken to, focused on, and singled out. In other words, *you* or *your* appeals to the reader's sense of self-worth.

The second group of pronouns (*we*, *us*, and *our*) uses team words to connote group involvement. These pronouns are especially valuable when writing to multiple audiences or when writing to subordinates. *We*, *us*, or *our* implies to the readers that "we're all in this together." Such a team concept helps motivate by making the readers feel an integral part of the whole.

The third group (*I*, *me*, and *my*) denotes the writer's involvement. If overused, however, these pronouns can connote egocentricity ("All I care about is *me*, *me*, *me*"). Because of this potential danger, emphasize *you* and *your* and downplay *I*, *me*, and *my*. Strive for a two-to-one ratio. For every *I*, *me*, or *my*, double your use of *you* or *your*.

Let's look at an automobile manufacturer's user manual, which omits pronouns and, thus, reads as if it is computer generated.

BEFORE

Claims Procedure

To obtain service under the Emissions Performance Warranty, take the vehicle to the company dealer as soon as possible after it fails an I/M test along with documentation showing that the vehicle failed an EPA-approved emissions test.

Without any pronouns, the version has no personality. It's dull and stiff, and it reads as if no human beings are involved.

Compare this flat, dry, dehumanized example with the more personalized version.

When pronouns are added in this version, the writing involves the reader on a personal level.

AFTER

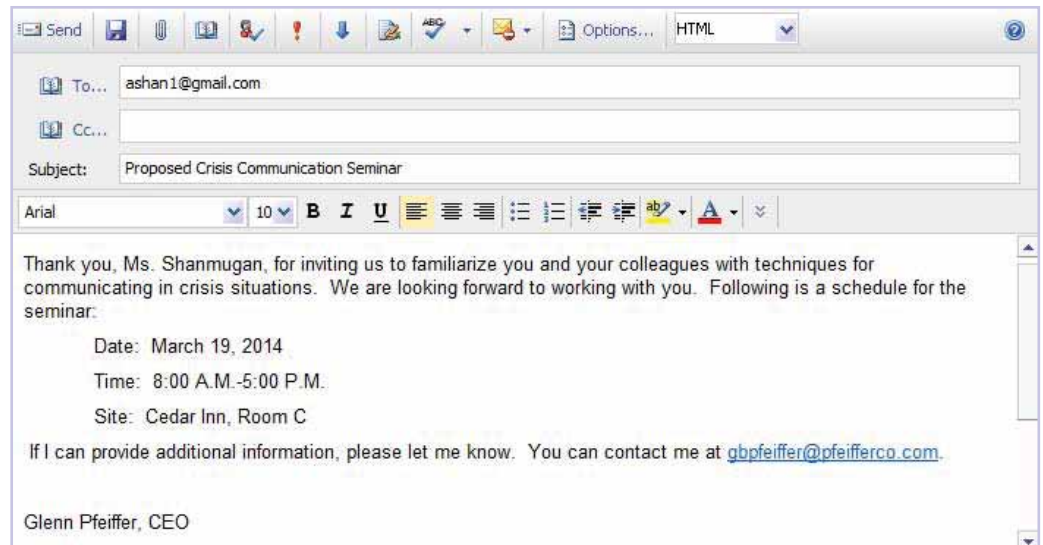
Claims Procedure

How do you get service under the Emissions Performance Warranty? To get service under this warranty, take your car to the dealer as soon as possible after it has failed an EPA-approved test. Be sure to bring along the document that shows your car failed the test.

Many writers believe that the first version is more professional. However, professionalism does not require that you write without personality. The pronoun-based writing in the second version is friendlier. Friendliness and humanism are positive attributes in technical communication. The second version also ensures reader involvement. As a professional, you want your readers (customers, clients, colleagues) to be involved, for without these readers no transaction occurs.

Names. Another way to personalize and achieve audience involvement is through use of names—incorporating the reader’s name in your technical communication. By doing so, you create a friendly reading environment in which you speak directly to your audience.

EXAMPLE ►



When do you use first names versus last names? If you know your reader well, have worked with him or her for a while, and know your reader will not be offended, then use the first name. However, if you do not know the reader well, have not worked with this reader before, or worry that the reader might be offended, then use the surname instead. In either instance, calling a reader by name will involve that reader and personalize your writing.

Reader Benefit

A final way to achieve audience involvement is to motivate your readers by giving them what they want or need. Show your audience how they will benefit from your technical communication.

Explain the Benefit. Until you tell your readers how they'll benefit, they may not know. Therefore, in your letter, e-mail, report, or manual, state the benefit clearly. You can do this anywhere, but you're probably wise to place the statement of benefit either early (first paragraph or abstract/summary) or late (last paragraph or conclusion). Placing the benefit early in the writing will interest readers and help ensure that they continue to read. Placing the benefit at the end could provide a motivational close, leaving readers with a positive impression.

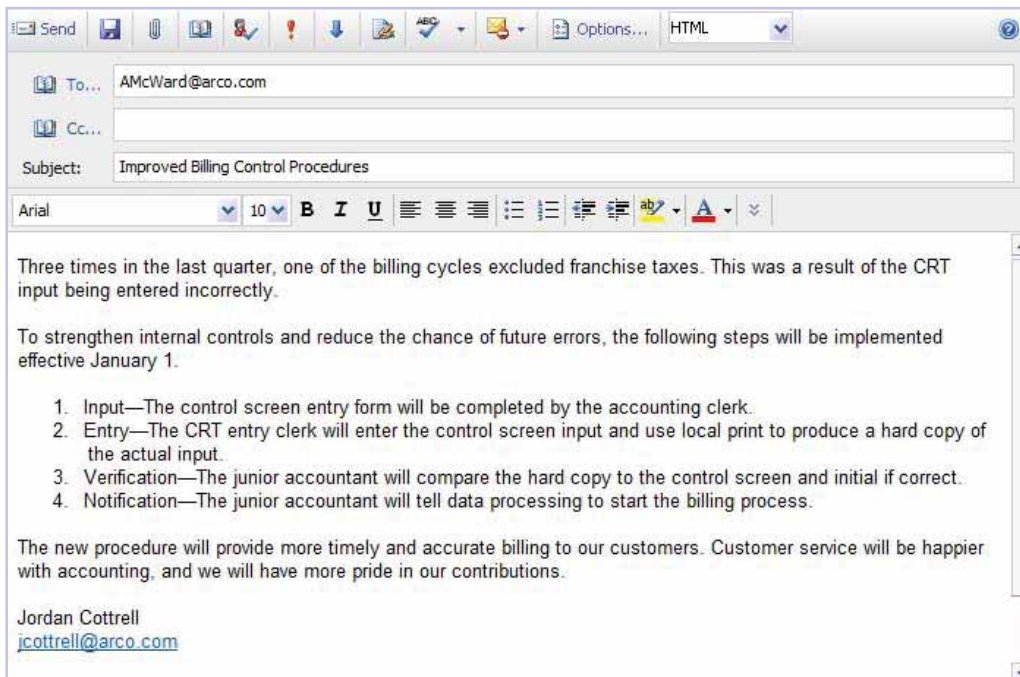
Instructions for Poured Foundations

A poured foundation will provide a level surface for mounting both the pump and motor. Carefully aligned equipment will provide you a longer and more easily maintained operation.

◀ EXAMPLE

This instruction conveys reader benefit.

E-mail messages can also develop reader benefit to involve audiences, as in the following example.



◀ EXAMPLE

The benefit is evident in the positive words—*improved, strengthen, reduce, timely, accurate, happier, pride, and contributions*. These words motivate readers by suggesting how they will benefit from their actions.

Reader benefit is emphasized in the last paragraph. The pronouns *we* and *our* in the last sentence involve the readers in the activity. A team concept is implied.

Use Positive Words. In the preceding examples of achieving reader benefit, the motivation or value is revealed through positive words. One way to involve your audience is to use positive words throughout your correspondence.

POSITIVE WORDS

accomplish	coordinate	favorable	plan	serve
achieve	create	guide	please	succeed
advantage	develop	happy	produce	support
appreciate	educate	help	profit	thank you
asset	effective	improve	promote	value
assist	efficient	increase	raise	
benefit	enjoy	lead	recommend	
build	ensure	maintain	reduce	
confident	establish	organize	satisfy	

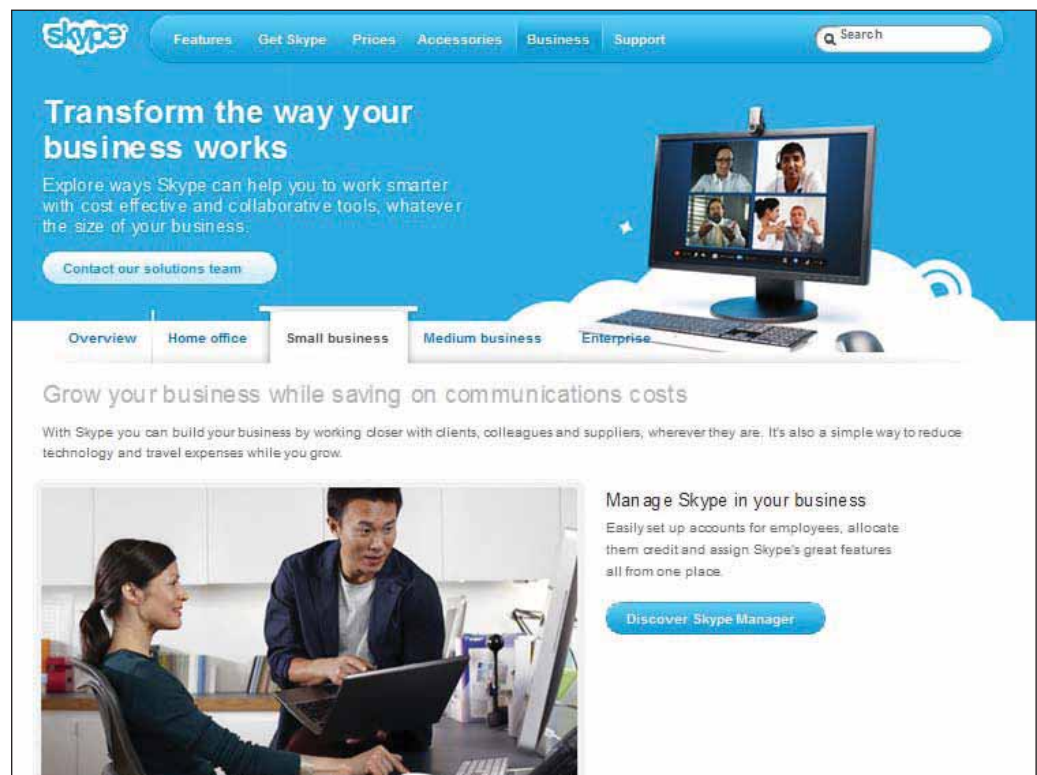
To clarify how important such words are, let's look at some examples of negative writing, followed by positive revisions.

BEFORE	AFTER
• We cannot process your request. You failed to follow the printed instructions. • The error is your fault. You keep your books incorrectly and cannot complain about our deliveries. If you would cooperate with us, we could solve your problem. • Your bill is now three weeks overdue. Failure to pay immediately will result in lower credit ratings.	• So that we may process your request rapidly, please fill in line 6 on the printed form. • To ensure prompt deliveries, let's get together to review our bookkeeping practices. Would next Tuesday be convenient? • If you're as busy as we are, you've probably misplaced our recent bill (mailed three weeks ago). Please send it in soon to maintain your high credit ratings.

Making something positive out of something negative is a challenge, but the rewards for doing so are great. If you attack your readers with negatives, you lose. When you involve your readers through positive words, you motivate them to work with you. See Figure 9 to learn how Skype involves audience through pronoun usage and positive words.

FIGURE 9 Skype Small Business

Skype uses positive words like *transform*, *help*, *smarter*, *cost effective*, *grow*, and *saving*. Pronouns *your* and *you* help to involve the audience. Finally, smiling workers make the site visually appealing and welcoming.



Source: Courtesy of Skype

AUDIENCE CHECKLIST

- _____ 1. What is my audience's level of understanding regarding the subject matter?
- High tech
 - Low tech
 - Lay
 - Multiple
- _____ 2. Given my audience's level of understanding, have I written accordingly?
- Have I defined my acronyms, abbreviations, and jargon?
 - Have I supplied enough background data?
 - Have I used the appropriate types of graphics?
- _____ 3. Who else might read my correspondence?
- How many people?
 - What are their levels of understanding?
 - High tech
 - Low tech
 - Lay
 - Will my audience be multicultural?
- _____ 4. What is my role in relation to my audience?
- Do I work for the reader?
 - Does the reader work for me?
 - Is the reader a peer?
 - Is the reader a client?
- _____ 5. What response do I want from my audience? Do I want my audience to act, respond, confirm, consider, decide, or file the information for future reference?
- _____ 6. Will my audience act according to my wishes? What is my audience's attitude toward the subject (and me)?
- Negative
 - Positive
 - Noncommittal
 - Uninformed
- _____ 7. Is my audience in a position of authority to act according to my wishes? If not, who will make the decision?
- _____ 8. What are my audience's personality traits?
- Slow to act
 - Eager
 - Receptive
 - Questioning
 - Organized
 - Disorganized
 - Oppositional
- _____ 9. Have I motivated my audience to act?
- Have I involved my reader in the correspondence by using pronouns and his or her name?
 - Have I shown my reader the benefit of the proposal by using positive words?
 - Have I considered any questions or objections my audience might have?
- _____ 10. Have I considered my audience's preferences regarding style?
- Is use of a first name appropriate?
- _____ 11. Have I avoided sexist language?
- Have I used *their* or *his* or *her* to avoid sexist singular pronouns such as *his*?
 - Have I used generic words such as *police officer* versus *policeman*?
 - Have I avoided excluding women, writing sentences such as "All present voted to accept the proposal" versus "All the men voted to accept the proposal"?
 - Have I avoided patronizing, writing sentences such as "Mr. Smith and Mrs. Brown wrote the proposal" versus "Mr. Smith and Judy wrote the proposal"?
- _____ 12. Have I considered diversity?
- Have I avoided any language that could offend various age groups, people of different sexual orientations, people with disabilities, or people of different cultures and religions?
 - Have I considered that people from different countries and people for whom English is a second language will be involved in the communication? This might mean that I should do the following:
 - Clarify time and measurements.
 - Define abbreviations and acronyms.
 - Avoid figurative language and idiomatic phrases, unique to one culture.
 - Avoid humor and puns.
 - Consider each country's cultural norms.

CHAPTER HIGHLIGHTS

1. High-tech readers understand acronyms, abbreviations, and jargon. However, not all of your readers will be high tech.
2. Low-tech readers need glossaries or parenthetical definitions of technical terms.
3. Lay readers usually will not understand technical terms. Consider providing these readers with extended definitions.

4. In addition to considering high-tech, low-tech, and lay audience levels, you also should consider issues of diversity, such as gender, race, religion, age, and sexual orientation.
5. Multiple audiences have different levels of technical knowledge. This fact affects the amount of technical content and terms you should include in your document.
6. The definition of a technical term usually includes its type and distinguishing characteristics but can also include examples, descriptions, and procedures.
7. For multicultural audiences, define terms, avoid jargon and idioms, and consider the context of the words you use. Avoid cultural biases, avoid slash marks, be careful with humor, and allow space for translation.
8. Half of your audience will be female, so you should avoid sexist language.
9. To get your audience involved in the text, personalize it by using pronouns and the reader's name.
10. Show your reader how he or she will benefit from your message or proposal.

APPLY YOUR KNOWLEDGE



CASE STUDY

Home and Business Mortgage (HBM) has suffered several lawsuits recently. A former employee sued the company, contending that it practiced ageism by promoting a younger employee over him. In an unrelated case, another employee contended that she was denied a raise due to her ethnicity. To combat these concerns, HBM has instituted new human resources practices. The goal is to ensure that the company meets all governmental personnel regulations, including those required by the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC), the Family Medical Leave Act (FMLA), and the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). HBM is committed to achieving diversity in its workplace.

HBM now needs to hire a new office manager for one of its branch operations. It has three outstanding candidates. Following are their credentials:

- **Carlos Gutierrez**—Carlos is a 27-year-old recent recipient of an MBA (masters in business administration) from an acclaimed business school. At this university, he learned many modern business applications, including capital budgeting, human resources management, organizational behavior, diversity management, accounting and marketing management, and team management strategies. He has been out of graduate school for only two years, but his work during that time has been outstanding. As an employee at one of HBM's branches, he has already impressed his bosses by increasing the branch's market share by 28 percent through innovative marketing strategies he learned in college. In addition, his colleagues enjoy working with him and praise his team-building skills. Carlos has never managed a staff, but he is filled with promise.
- **Cheryl Huff**—Cheryl is a 37-year-old employee of a rival mortgage company, Farm-Ranch Equity. She has a BGS (bachelor's degree in general studies) from a local university, which she acquired while working full time in the mortgage and real estate business. At Farm-Ranch, where she has worked for over 15 years, she has moved up the ladder, acquiring many new levels of responsibility. After working as an executive assistant for five years, she then became a mortgage payoff clerk for two years, a loan processor for two years, a mortgage sales manager for four years, and, most recently, a residential mortgage closing

coordinator for the last two years. In the last two positions, she managed a staff of five employees.

According to her references, she has been dependable on the job. Her references also suggest that she is a forceful taskmaster. Though she has accomplished much on the job, her subordinates have complained about her demanding expectations. Her references suggest, perhaps, that she could profit from some improved people skills.

- **Rose Massin**—Rose is 47 years old and has been out of the workforce for 12 years. During that absence, she raised a family of three children. Now, the youngest child is in school, and Rose wants to re-enter the job market. She has a bachelor's degree in business and was the former office manager of this HBM branch. Thus, she has management experience, as well as mortgage experience.

While she was branch manager, she did an outstanding job. This included increasing business, working well with employees and clients, and maintaining excellent relationships with lending banks and realtors. She was a highly respected employee and was involved in civic activities and community volunteerism. In fact, she is immediate past-president of the local Rotary Club. Though she has been out of the workforce for years, she has kept active in the city and has maintained excellent business contacts. Still, she's a bit rusty on modern business practices.

Assignment

Whom will you hire from these three candidates? Based on the information provided, make your hiring decision. This is a judgment call. Be sure to substantiate your decision with as much proof as possible. Then share this finding as follows:

- **Oral Presentations**—Give a 3–5 minute presentation to share with your colleagues the results of your decision.
- **Written**—Write an e-mail, memo, or report about your findings.

INDIVIDUAL AND TEAM PROJECTS

Avoiding Sexist Language

1. Revise the following sentences to avoid sexist language.
 - a. All the software development specialists and their wives attended the conference.
 - b. The foremen met to discuss techniques for handling union grievances.
 - c. Every technician must keep accurate records for his monthly activity reports.
 - d. The president of the corporation, a woman, met with her sales staff.
 - e. Throughout the history of mankind, each scientist has tried to make his mark with a discovery of significant intellectual worth.

Achieving Audience Involvement

1. Revise the following sentences to achieve reader involvement and benefit, using positive words and pronouns.
 - a. We cannot lay your cable until you sign the attached waiver.
 - b. John, don't purchase the wrong program. If we continue to keep inefficient records, our customers will continue to complain.
 - c. You have not paid your bill yet. Failure to do so might result in termination of services.
 - d. If you incorrectly quote and paraphrase, you will receive an *F* on the assignment.
 - e. Your team has lost 6 of their last 12 games.
2. Rewrite the following flawed correspondence. Its tone is too negative and commanding, regardless of the audience. Soften the tone to achieve better audience involvement and motivation.

To: Staff

Subject: Fourth Quarter Goals

Due to a severe lack of discipline, the company failed to meet third quarter goals. To avoid repeating this disaster for the fourth quarter, this is what I think you all must do—ASAP.

1. Demand that the sales department increase cold calls by 15 percent.
2. Require weekly progress reports by all sales staff.
3. Penalize employees when reports are not provided on time.
4. Tell managers to keep on top of their staff, pushing them to meet these goals.

Remember, when one link is weak in the chain, the entire company suffers. DON'T BE THE WEAK LINK!

Defining Terms for Different Audience Levels

1. Find examples of definitions provided in computer word processing programs, e-mail packages, Internet dictionaries, and online help screens. Determine whether these examples provide the *term*, its *type*, and its *distinguishing characteristics*. Are the definitions effective? If so, explain why. If not, rewrite the definitions for clarity.
2. In small groups composed of individuals from similar majors, list ten high-tech terms (jargon, acronyms, or abbreviations) unique to your degree programs. Then, envisioning a lay audience, parenthetically define and briefly explain these terms. To test the success of your communication abilities, orally share these high-tech terms with other students who have different majors.
 - State the high-tech term to see if they understand it.
 - If they don't, provide the parenthetical definition. How much does this help? Do they understand now?
 - If they still do not understand the definition, add the third step—the brief explanation. How much information do the readers need before they understand your high-tech terms?

Recognizing Issues of Diversity

1. Rewrite the following sentences for multicultural, cross-cultural audiences.
 - a. Let's meet at 8:30 P.M.
 - b. The best size for this new component is $16 \times 23 \times 41$.
 - c. To keep us out of the red, we need to round up employees who can put their pedal to the metal and get us out of this hole.
 - d. We need to produce fliers/brochures to increase business.
 - e. The meeting is planned for 07/09/14.
2. Rewrite the following flawed correspondence. Be sure to consider your multicultural or cross-cultural audience's needs.

From: Nachman Sumani

Subject: Brainstorming

I need to pick your brain, guys. We've got a big one coming up, a killer deal with a major European player. Before I can make the pitch, however, let's brainstorm solutions. The client needs a proposal by December 5, so I need your input before that date. Give me your ideas about the following:

- What should we charge for our product, if the client buys in bulk?
- What's our turnaround time for production? I know that your people tend to work slowly, so can you hurry the team up if I promise delivery in six weeks?

E-mail me your feedback by tomorrow, 1:00 p.m., at the latest. Trust me, guys. If we blow this one, everyone's bonuses will be out the window.

PROBLEM-SOLVING THINK PIECE

Dove Hill, GA, experienced severe thunderstorms on March 15. Goodwin & Associates Insurance Co. (GAI) insured much of the territory affected by this storm. Over 1,200 houses insured by GAI had water damage. As written, the homeowner's policy provided full-replacement coverage for water damage. In the homeowner's policies, water damage was limited to situations such as the following:

- A hailstorm smashes a window, permitting hail and rain to enter a home.
- A heavy rain soaks through a roof, allowing water to drip through a ceiling.
- A broken water pipe spews water into a home.

In contrast, homes that suffered water damage due to flooding were not covered, unless the homeowners also had taken out a separate flood damage policy from the National Flood Insurance Program. For insurance purposes, *flood* is defined as "the rising of a body of water onto normally dry land." For example, flood damage can include a river overflowing its banks or a heavy rain seeping into a basement. Of the 1,200 homes suffering water damage, only 680 homes qualified for full replacement coverage. The remaining homes suffered flood damage and were thus not covered.

Assignment

Write a letter or e-mail message from GAI to a homeowner denying coverage for their water damage claim. You are writing as a high-tech insurance professional to a lay reader. You want to maintain a good business relationship, despite the bad news. Build rapport while specifying in lay terms the denial.

WEB WORKSHOP

You are head of international relations at your corporation. Your company is preparing to go global. To ensure that your company is sensitive to multicultural concerns, research the cultural traits and business practices in five countries of your choice. To do so, access an online search engine and type in "multicultural business practices in _____" (specify the country's name). Report your findings either orally or in an e-mail.